Butcher & Blackbird

A Companion Guide

Book. Brynne Weaver, 2023. The Ruinous Love Trilogy, Book 1.

Guide generated September 14, 2026

Spoiler tier: FULL. This guide discusses the entire plot, including the ending and the setup for the rest of the trilogy.

Quick Take

Butcher & Blackbird is a friends-to-lovers romantic comedy in which both leads are serial killers who only hunt other serial killers. Sloane Sutherland, the Orb Weaver, is a methodical data scientist who takes her victims' eyes. Rowan Kane, the Boston Butcher, is a tattooed Irish chef with what BookTok calls golden retriever energy. They meet when she is locked in a cage with a corpse, and he takes her to lunch. The book is genuinely funny, genuinely sweet, and genuinely disgusting, often on the same page. That combination did not exist in mass-market romance before this book, and it is why a self-published ebook from a Nova Scotia farm became a New York Times bestseller, launched a publishing imprint, and got a film deal within a year.

Is it worth reading? If you can tolerate graphic gore and explicit sex, yes, and the audiobook is the way to do it. The critical consensus, such as it is, lands on the same phrase over and over: a rom-com, albeit a gruesome one. The most common complaint is structural. The romance resolves around the three-quarter mark and the final villain shows up late, so the last act can feel bolted on. Goodreads readers split hard, which is what you would expect from a book that puts a cookies-and-cream ice cream scene in the middle of a love story. It is not a great novel. It is a great time, and it knows exactly what it is.

About the Author

Brynne Weaver is a pen name. She is Canadian, grew up between Nova Scotia and Ontario, and wrote Butcher & Blackbird on a farm in Pictou County, Nova Scotia. On December 11, 2023, the day before the trade edition hit shelves, she moved with her husband and son to Chicago. CBC News covered her as a local-girl-makes-good story before most American readers knew where she was from.

Her pre-writing career explains a lot about the book. According to her publisher's bio, she worked as a forensic archaeologist, an equestrian professional, and a specialist in neuroscience and pharmaceutical research and development. A 2025 podcast interview adds that she holds a master's degree in forensic archaeology and did body-farm research. The clinical precision of the body disposal in her books, and the way Sloane approaches a kill like a lab protocol, comes from someone who has studied decomposition professionally.

Butcher & Blackbird was not her first book. It was roughly her seventh. Her official bibliography runs: The Diviner (2021, fantasy romance debut); The Shadow Realm trilogy beginning with A Shadow in the Reaping (2021), which she describes as a neon romantasy paranormal dark romcom; and two co-written standalones, Black Sheep (2022) and Marrow (2023, with Trisha Wolfe). Marrow matters here. It pairs two rival serial killers in an enemies-to-lovers plot and reads as a dry run for the tone she perfected a few months later.

Weaver has been candid that the earlier books were practice. She told Rolling Stone she moved from fantasy to paranormal to contemporary dark romance with the express purpose of learning how to crack self-publishing. Her words: it was a process of continuously wanting to learn how to crack it and how to get better and better. That makes the BookTok explosion sound engineered, but she told Parade she self-published without a pre-order and never sent

the book to a single creator. They picked it up on their own and started shouting about it. She planned the craft. She did not plan the marketing.

Since the trilogy she has become, by her publisher's marketing, the Queen of Dark Romcom. The Seasons of Carnage trilogy followed: Tourist Season (September 2025, an instant number one New York Times bestseller), Harvest Season (June 2026, also number one), and Hunting Season (scheduled for April 6, 2027). A novella called Love Antidote, about an assassin pastry chef who accidentally poisons a rival hitman, arrives from Amazon Original Stories on September 15, 2026, the day after this guide was written.

The Story, Start to Finish

This section is the full plot. Skip it if you have not finished the book.

The cage and the game

Sloane Sutherland kills serial killer Albert Briscoe but ends up locked in his cage with the body for three days. Rowan Kane, hunting the same man, finds the keys, lets her out, and takes her to lunch. He proposes a game: every year they will get one week to hunt the same target, first kill wins, best of five earns bragging rights and a shot at a killer who tops both their lists. Rowan's older brother Lachlan, a leatherworker and contract killer, texts them the first location.

Year one is a small town in West Virginia. The innkeeper, Francis, warns them off a trail where hikers keep vanishing, which is how they know he is the killer. Rowan catches Francis peeping at Sloane, jumps on the hood of his car, smashes the windshield, crashes him into a tree, and beats him to death. Along the way Rowan confides that he and Lachlan killed their abusive father, the night Rowan got his lip scar, and that their mother died giving birth to Fionn, the youngest brother, now a doctor. Sloane's first kill was the art teacher who assaulted her best friend Lark Montague. Both of them come from harm and both turned it into a vocation.

The cannibal, the ice cream, and the mummy

Year two moves to upscale California and a Hannibal-style cannibal named Thorsten. Sloane realizes Rowan has been tailing her instead of doing his own research. At dinner Thorsten drugs Rowan, who passes out face-first in a meal he did not know was human. Sloane stays sharp, ties Thorsten up, tortures him, and kills him. This is the house with the ice cream. Searching the kitchen, Sloane finds homemade cookies-and-cream ice cream in the freezer, labeled with the dates the key ingredient was collected. The scene is the single most-discussed moment in the fandom, and it is also a clue. Thorsten's servant David, apparently lobotomized and fed human matter, is left behind. Rowan chooses to play dumb about what he ate and what he said while drugged, and later hires David at his restaurant out of something like guilt.

Year three is rural Texas and Harvey Mead, a chainsaw killer in a decaying farmhouse who is fixated on his dead, mummified mother. He nearly kills Sloane. She finishes him by dragging the mummified corpse across him until he dies of fright. The author's content warning about misuse of a mummified corpse refers to this scene. Then a Boston gala, a killer who kicks Sloane's shoulder out of its socket, and Rowan finally admitting he cannot lose her. They kiss, become

official, and Sloane relocates to Boston. The book is about three-quarters done, and the romance is settled.

The twist, the ring, and the Phantom

Rowan opens a second restaurant and names it Butcher & Blackbird, with a permanently reserved booth for Sloane. Then the twist: David was never lobotomized. He is the South Bay Slasher, and he has been waiting. He abducts Rowan and tortures him in the restaurant kitchen, flaying him and working with a corkscrew. Sloane tracks them and kills David with a scalpel.

After the cleanup, still in the kitchen, Rowan proposes. The ring has been hidden inside a previous victim's eye socket, and the question is scrawled on a paper napkin. That one object is the whole book in miniature: a romance-novel gesture built out of serial-killer material. They marry in a small ceremony with the Kane brothers and Lark. Lachlan walks Sloane down the aisle.

The epilogue introduces the Phantom, a nomadic Pacific Northwest killer who has been watching. He claims David was his brother and vows to take one of Rowan's brothers in return. Lark moves to Boston. Book two, Leather & Lark, pairs her with Lachlan and picks up the Phantom thread.

What the Critics Say

The strangest thing about this book's reception is how little of it exists in the usual places. Kirkus never reviewed it. Publishers Weekly covered the industry story (the imprint launch, the bestseller lists) but never ran a review. No Library Journal, Booklist, or major newspaper review surfaced. A book that sold in the millions did so with essentially no prepublication trade coverage. Its critical record lives on Goodreads, BookTok, podcasts, and romance blogs.

Genre press

> *A light, fun, friends-to-lovers romantic comedy, that just also happens to have very gruesome and graphic torture scenes. It worries me how much I enjoyed this book.* (The Good, The Bad and The Unread, grade A)
>
> *At its heart this is a rom-com, albeit a gruesome one.* (Forever Young Adult, 9 out of 10)
>
> *Equal parts romance, revenge, and light cannibalism.* (Lose the Plot)

Smart Bitches, Trashy Books gave it a B-minus and named the structural problem most readers notice. By about 75 percent in, the main conflict has resolved and the characters have achieved happiness, then a bleak moment adds new danger. The reviewer called the plot uneven but praised the series for being funny and over the top in an amusing way. Even the A-grade reviews agree on this flaw. The David twist lands after the romance has already paid off.

Readers

Goodreads as of the day this guide was built:

Book	Average	Ratings
Butcher & Blackbird (2023)	4.00	694,749
Leather & Lark (2024)	4.00	344,141
Scythe & Sparrow (2025)	4.07	228,926
Love & Other Killers novella (2025)	3.97	59,059

A 4.00 on nearly 700,000 ratings is enormous volume with a middling average, which is the signature of a polarizing book. The ratings count roughly halves with each sequel, which is the clearest measure of how far beyond the core audience book one reached. The praise and the pans are consistent in what they name.

> *Stimulating, scorching, action-packed ... seamlessly blending thriller, mystery, dark comedy, and erotic romance genres.* (Goodreads, 5 stars)
>
> *Under-developed characters, insta-lovey, boring plot, bad writing, and awful dialogue.* (Goodreads, 1 star)

Recurring reader complaints: overuse of nicknames, characters who lack depth, and mismatched expectations from people who wanted either a true dark romance or a true rom-com and got a hybrid. One Goodreads reviewer summed up a whole camp of readers with the line that they liked it right up until the characters started getting freaky. The Trigger Warning Romance podcast coined the label that fans now use unironically: fluffy dark romance.

Lists and honors

The honors are commercial, not award-based. Butcher & Blackbird hit the New York Times trade paperback list in March 2024 and was number eight on Publishers Weekly's trade paperback list in June 2024, the same week Leather & Lark debuted as the number two book in the country. Scythe & Sparrow was an instant number one New York Times bestseller with a 500,000-copy announced first printing. No Goodreads Choice Award nomination could be confirmed for any book in the trilogy.

Sales figures need a caveat. Publishers Weekly calls the trilogy a multimillion-copy success. Author bios claim four to five million copies across 25-plus countries, but those are self-reported totals across all her books, not audited and not specific to this title. The one hard number is from March 2024: nearly 100,000 copies sold, with the hashtag at 24 million TikTok views.

Themes and What Makes It Work

The rules make the ethics easy, on purpose

Sloane and Rowan only kill killers, and the book never lets a target be ambiguous. Every victim is a child abuser, a cannibal, or a torturer. Writer Koji A. Dae calls this peak narrative inversion: the killers become protagonists because they target society's predators, and the book gives them a sympathetic backstory, a society-aligned moral code, physical attractiveness, and no remorse.

That last part is the tell. Dexter agonizes. Sloane and Rowan are enthusiastic. The book is not asking whether vigilante murder is right. It is asking whether you will admit you are enjoying it.

Masking, and the relief of being seen

Both leads spend their lives performing normal. Sloane is a data scientist with a quiet apartment. Rowan runs restaurants and charms everyone. The romance works because each recognizes the mask on the other. Dae again: finding another person who masks as constantly is a relief. Strip out the murder and this is a familiar romance engine, two people who can finally stop pretending. The murder is what makes the pretending so heavy.

Tropes played straight by monsters

Weaver has said the inspiration came from doomscrolling the TikTok red flag, green flag trend, where readers mock possessive heroes, instant obsession, and the touch her and die school of romance. Her move was to reclaim the disparaged tropes by handing them to two people for whom the tropes are literally true. Rowan is possessive because he is a killer. Sloane's independence is a survival skill. The tropes stop being cringe when the stakes match the intensity.

Structure: the game as calendar

The book alternates first-person chapters between Rowan and Sloane and skips a year between hunts. West Virginia, California, Texas, Boston. That lets a slow burn play out over three years inside 350 pages without the middle sagging, because every section opens with a new kill and a new rung on the relationship ladder. Gore escalates, intimacy escalates, and the reader gets both rewards on the same schedule. It is also why the ending feels off to so many readers. Once the game concludes and the couple settles, the book has to invent a new engine, and David is that engine.

Order meets chaos

The character design is clean. Sloane is methodical and organized, turning victims into what one reviewer called twisted art projects. Rowan is flirty chaos. Readers reach for the black cat and golden retriever shorthand constantly, and it fits. The comedy comes from the mismatch and the romance comes from each one covering what the other lacks. Rowan literally cannot stop himself from following Sloane instead of doing his own research, and she cannot stop herself from being irritated and flattered at the same time.

Why it was new

Dark romance circa 2022 to 2023 was mostly grim and often built on non-consent. Haunting Adeline was the lightning rod. Butcher & Blackbird kept the gore and dropped the misery, pairing two consenting equals who like each other and like what they do. Zando's Slowburn imprint built its list on that tonal split, following with Navessa Allen's Lights Out. Weaver's publisher calls her a pioneer of the dark romcom. The claim is marketing, but it is also roughly true.

What You Might Not Know

- Four months from indie ebook to trade paperback. Weaver self-published in August 2023. Two days after release, narrator Joe Arden contacted her about recording a dual narration. The audiobook (Arden as Rowan, Lucy Rivers as Sloane, 8 hours 43 minutes) dropped October 10, 2023. Zando's trade edition followed December 12, 2023. The publisher is Molly Stern's indie Zando, distributed by Penguin Random House, not a Big Five house.
- It built an imprint. Publishers Weekly's March 2024 report on Zando's new Slowburn romance imprint reads as a Butcher & Blackbird story. Co-director Hayley Wagreich: from the minute it landed in our inboxes, we knew it was unlike anything. Slowburn's inaugural title was the sequel.
- The audiobook is a true duet. Both narrators recorded together and voice full conversations. Multiple reviewers say it is the superior way to experience the book, and Arden's Irish accent for Rowan is singled out. Caveat: in March 2024, anonymous misconduct allegations against Arden circulated on TikTok and elsewhere. They are unproven, and no statement from Weaver or re-recording was found. Some reviewers now steer readers to print.
- The content warnings are part of the marketing. Weaver's site calls the list for this book the craziest one and confirms everything really does happen: eyeballs and eye sockets, amateur surgery, chainsaws, accidental and intentional cannibalism, misuse of a mummified corpse, and a long list of explicit sex content. The list itself became a BookTok bit.
- Special editions keep it on the lists. A US Collector's Edition hardcover (November 2024) has illustrated endpapers, a letter from the author, and hot fuchsia sprayed edges. Rights sold in at least 15 countries by mid-2024, including a French edition from Seuil's Verso label translated, per the publisher, from Canadian English.
- Sloane's day job is data science. Rowan's is running restaurants. The book is quietly a workplace comedy about two people whose careers are covers.
- The eye-socket ring and the ice cream are the fandom's two landmarks. Merch iconography runs to eyes, blackbirds, and cookies-and-cream. The film's director reposted fan-made themed cookies in 2025.
- The game outlived the book. Love & Other Killers, a 61-page Amazon Original novella (August 2025), runs the annual hunt again with the entire Kane family split into teams. BookTok had been expecting casting news that day and got a novella instead.
- Weaver published an official Spotify playlist for the book, and fans do a tandem read of the trilogy, switching chapter by chapter between books where the timelines overlap. First-timers should read in publication order.

On Screen

A film adaptation is real but stalled in development. Variety broke the news on June 27, 2024: Chris McKay (The Lego Batman Movie, Renfield) will direct for Lyrical Media and Ryder Picture Company, with Weaver as executive producer. Deadline added screenwriter Laura Kosann on January 17, 2025. Kosann's credits run from an R.L. Stine project at Netflix to the comedy Hi,

Mom and the 2022 Black List script Semper Maternus, which is a reasonable range for a book that needs kid-horror gross-out timing and rom-com banter in the same scene.

Weaver posted a photo of the completed script in June 2025 and in December 2025 teased that the ice cream scene made it in. The stated plan was to cast once the script was locked and shoot in late fall or early winter. As of September 2026, the producer's own project page still lists the film as in development with no cast, no distributor, and no release date. Letterboxd lists it as released. Letterboxd is wrong.

Weaver's only public casting opinion, from a February 2025 interview, was Nicholas Hoult for Rowan and praise for Amber Midthunder. Fan casts cluster around Paul Mescal, Aaron Taylor-Johnson, and Robert Sheehan for Rowan and Florence Pugh, Sophie Thatcher, and Ella Purnell for Sloane. None of that is casting news. The credit fans point to as proof McKay fits is Renfield, an R-rated film that plays gore for laughs, which is exactly this book's register. The open question is whether a studio keeps the sex scenes, which ScreenRant argued carry the friends-to-lovers arc and cannot be cut without turning the leads into any other romantic couple.

If You Liked This

Finish the trilogy first

- Leather & Lark (June 2024). Lachlan Kane and Lark Montague in a fake-marriage, hate-to-love plot with the Phantom as the villain. Number one on the New York Times list and the most divisive entry: better romance and spice, but readers miss the murder games and the humor.
- Scythe & Sparrow (February 2025). Dr. Fionn Kane, a heartbroken small-town Nebraska physician in a crochet club, meets Rose Evans, a circus motorcycle performer who kills abusers and, in Weaver's words, really tries hard. Some call it a rebound after book two, others call it watered down.
- Love & Other Killers (August 2025). The novella that reruns the game with the whole family and bridges to the Seasons of Carnage trilogy.

Then try these

1. Marrow by Trisha Wolfe and Brynne Weaver (2023). A forensic anthropologist and a wildlife biologist, both serial killers, enemies to lovers. The closest structural match, and Weaver co-wrote it before this book.
2. Lights Out by Navessa Allen (2024). A trauma nurse and a masked stalker with a serial-killer father. Reviewers keep using the same word for it that they use for Butcher & Blackbird: funny. Fourteen weeks on the New York Times list; the sequel Caught Up arrived June 2025.
3. My Sister, the Serial Killer by Oyinkan Braithwaite (2018). A literary black comedy about cleaning up after your sister's dead boyfriends. Anthony Award and LA Times Book Prize winner. For a book club that wants the humor without the spice.
4. Darkly Dreaming Dexter by Jeff Lindsay (2004). The template for kills-only-killers vigilante logic, with the Showtime series as a chaser.

5. You by Caroline Kepnes (2014). First-person killer narration with charm and menace. For the you-rooted-for-him-now-think-about-why angle.
6. Does It Hurt? by H.D. Carlton. Predator-and-prey dark romance with more menace than Weaver and less than Haunting Adeline. For readers who want the dial turned darker.

Companion listening and reading

- Trigger Warning Romance, season 3 episode 4 (March 2024). The episode that coined fluffy dark romance. The hosts warn you not to eat while listening.
- Romantasy Reads podcast ran a two-part deep dive starting September 2024. We Read It One Night covered it in January 2026.
- Rolling Stone, Why BookTok Is Absolutely Obsessed With Dark Romance. Weaver is interviewed and credits BookTok and self-publishing with routing around the gatekeeping that kept dark romance out of traditional houses.
- SuperSummary has a 24-chapter study guide with essay topics, if you want the homework version.

Book club questions

7. Sloane and Rowan only kill killers. Does that rule make them moral, or is it just a permission slip? Where does the book itself land?
8. Weaver pairs graphic gore with rom-com banter. When did the humor make the violence easier to take, and when did it make it worse?
9. The annual game gives the novel its structure. What does the competition let the two of them say to each other that a normal courtship would not?
10. Sloane's first kill was the teacher who assaulted Lark. Does the book treat that origin as trauma, as vocation, or as both? Did it change how you judged her later kills?
11. The Kane brothers are a found family of killers. What does the book say about who gets to be family?
12. Rowan is possessive and Sloane is fiercely independent. Is their dynamic romantic, alarming, or both? How would you feel about it in a non-killer couple?
13. The ice cream scene is the book's signature gross-out and also a plot clue. Why put the clue in a dessert, and what does it tell you about David?
14. The romance resolves at about the three-quarter mark. Did the David twist feel earned or bolted on?
15. Fluffy dark romance: fair label? Where would you shelve this, dark romance, rom-com, or thriller?
16. The film's director made Renfield and The Lego Batman Movie. Which scene would you fight to keep, and which would you expect a studio to cut?

A Note on Verification

Two agents gathered this material from the open web on September 14, 2026. Several details could not be confirmed and were left out: the cannibal Thorsten's surname (sources disagree), any taxidermy or Christmas-dinner scene, and a Goodreads Choice nomination. The Guardian,

New York Times, Vulture, and Reddit were unreachable, so nothing is cited from them. Goodreads figures are as of the fetch date and move daily. Sales totals above four million are publisher and author claims, not audited counts.

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